

New heights: In 2025, Afsal set a national record of 1:45.61 in the 800m at a meet in Dubai. Just two months later, he lowered it further, clocking 1:44.93 in Poland. M. PERIASAMY

fourth. "That really hurt my ego," he says. Manoj remembers a shattered Afsal after that race. "He was weeping and told me, 'If I had listened to you, I could have won.'"

And thus, at the age of 13, reality dawned on Afsal — without hard work, success would continue to elude him. "From that day, I did whatever Manoj Sir asked me to do," says Afsal. "Slowly, training became an addiction for me."

The change in attitude immediately translated into success, as he went from being medal-less at the sub-junior state level to sweeping all the middle- and long-distance titles in his age category.

Afsal's drive, though, was hit by a practical predicament. Because of Palakkad's heat, the training sessions in Parali used to start at 5.30 am and run until the start of school at 9 am.

The first bus from Afsal's hometown to Parali was at 6.30 am. This meant he would reach only by 7.15 am, by which time the other kids, mostly from nearby areas, would be halfway through their training.

Afsal's parents made some enquiries and found a canny solution — local newspaper distributors agreed to drop him off at his school in their vans for just Rs. 10. The only issue: they plied the route at around 3 am.

Consumed by his obsession with training, Afsal went along with the plan. But now there was another problem — he was way too early for training. He solved it by getting a small roll-on mattress for his school.

"Every morning, for almost two hours, I would be all alone in school, with just a torch in my hand. With nothing else to do, I would sneak in a quick nap," says Afsal.

The first person to greet coach Manoj at training every morning

would invariably be Afsal. "It just shows his character and commitment. That is the root of all his success," admits Manoj.

Despite all his idealistic qualities, Afsal has no qualms about admitting that his early athletic pursuits had a materialistic motive.

Running in state and national meets (**right**), he bagged cash prizes, gold coins, cycles and even a Tata Nano car. But there was something even more priceless.

"Once I started winning medals and my picture started appearing in the news, the newspaper vans stopped taking money from me. In fact, they used to argue among themselves for the right to get me to school," reminisces Afsal.

Soon after he cleared his 12th, he made a breakthrough at the national level. In 2015, Afsal won bronze in the 800m event at the National Games.

This proved pivotal in two ways — one, he locked in on the 800m as his primary event; two, he earned a job with the Air Force.

Eager to prove himself at the senior level, Afsal pushed on. In 2018, he touched 1:46.00 for the first time. But it came in a race where another Malayalee stole the limelight — Jinson Johnson, who broke the long-standing 800m national record (NR).

Once again, Afsal aspired to replicate a peer's glory. "When Jinson



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

